Before You Sign: A Car Financing & Leasing Decision Guide

I spent roughly $69,000 on cars over about 4½ years.

And I don't have a car to show for it. Understand the full cost, consider your alternatives, and check your assumptions before committing to a car payment.

A simple car-decision guide for anyone about to take on a car payment they could regret for years.

20 minutes · 6 lessons · 1 framework

> 💡 **WHY THIS EXISTS**
>
> I'm not a financial advisor.
>
> I'm someone who learned this the expensive way.
>
> I can't promise this guide will save you $69,000.
>
> What I can do is show you how my first financial decision became a chain of decisions that followed me for years and give you the framework I wish I'd had before the first domino fell.

You don't need to make perfect financial decisions.

You need to stop making expensive decisions on autopilot.

Read the story.

Notice the patterns.

Then use the tool at the end on a real decision you're facing.

I

HOW A CAR PROBLEM BECAME A $69,000 LESSON

My car problems started with a free BMW.

Around early 2022, my uncle gave me an older BMW 5 Series.

Free car, right?

Except it wasn't really free.

The car needed work, and I had a decision to make.

Looking back, one reasonable option would have been to sell it, take whatever I could get for it, and put that money toward a cheap, reliable car.

Instead, I traded it into a dealership for around $1,500 and financed a Kia Niro.

The payment was around **$467/month**.

At the time, that number felt manageable.

And that's where the story really begins.

THEN THE FIRST NIRO GOT TOTALED.

About six months later, I got into an accident and the car was totaled.

I needed another car.

And I was thinking about the problem in front of me:

> **“I need a car.”**

So about two weeks later, I bought another new Kia Niro.

This time, the payment was around **$732/month**.

Again, it didn't feel like a $69,000 decision.

It felt like a solution to an immediate problem.

THEN THE SECOND NIRO STARTED HAVING PROBLEMS.

The transmission problems went on for months.

I was overwhelmed.

I was angry.

I felt trapped.

I wanted out.

Eventually, I left the Kia at the dealership thinking that somehow walking away from it would make the problem disappear.

It didn't.

The commitment didn't disappear.

Now I had created another problem.

SO I GOT A TESLA.

Five days after making my last Kia payment, I leased a Tesla Model 3.

I had roughly $2,500 upfront and a monthly lease payment around $600.

At the time, I was making around $4,000/month and paying roughly $1,100 in rent.

The Tesla felt like the solution.

But the Kia commitment hadn't disappeared.

Now I had two problems.

THEN CAME THE FORTE.

I realized I couldn't just leave the Kia situation hanging.

A friend helped me trade the Niro into a Kia Forte.

Because of the negative equity and the way the deal worked out, I ended up with another payment—around $650/month.

For roughly a year, I was carrying two cars and all the associated costs.

Eventually, I surrendered the Forte loan.

That decision affected my friend's credit.

And after all of that, the Tesla remained.

The Tesla itself wasn't just a $600 payment.

There was insurance.

There was charging.

There were other vehicle expenses.

The payment was only one piece of the cost.

And the cycle continued.

THE PART THAT FUCKS WITH ME

Over roughly 4½ years, I estimate that I spent around **$69,000 on cars.**

And after all of that:

I DON'T HAVE A CAR TO SHOW FOR IT.

I didn't end up with the financial freedom I wanted.

I ended up broke.

Eventually, my financial situation became bad enough that I returned to my home country.

For a long time, I looked at that as:

> **“I wasted my opportunity in LA.”**

Maybe I did make mistakes.

A lot of them.

But I don't think it serves me—or anyone reading this—to pretend the only conclusion is:

> **“I fucked up, so that's it.”**

Because there is another way to look at it.

I can't go back.

I can't get the money back.

I can't undo the decisions.

But I can make the experience useful.

And maybe someone reading this can recognize themselves **before** they have to learn the same lesson.

That's the entire reason this exists.

II

THE 6 LESSONS I WISH SOMEONE HAD TAUGHT ME

01 — THE ESCAPE DECISION

This was probably my biggest mistake.

I kept trying to escape the problem I was currently experiencing.

Car problem?

Get another car.

That car has problems?

Get out of that car.

Now you have two commitments?

Trade one.

Negative equity?

Roll it into something else.

Feeling overwhelmed?

Make another decision.

Looking back, I can see the pattern.

I wasn't solving the original problem anymore.

I was trying to escape the discomfort created by the previous decision.

And every escape created another commitment.

> **ASK YOURSELF**
>
> Am I solving the problem, or am I trying to escape how this problem makes me feel?

Those are not always the same thing.

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02 — THE PAYMENT ISN'T THE COST

A monthly payment can make almost anything look affordable.

$467/month.

$600/month.

$650/month.

$732/month.

Your brain sees one number.

But the real decision might include the payment, insurance, fuel or charging, maintenance, registration, fees, interest, upfront costs, existing debt, negative equity, opportunity cost, and the consequences of your income changing.

The question isn't:

> **“Can I make this payment?”**

The better question is:

> **“What is this decision actually going to cost me?”**

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03 — FREE ISN'T FREE

That BMW was given to me.

It was technically free.

But a free car that requires thousands of dollars to keep running isn't necessarily a good deal.

Something can have a $0 purchase price and still be expensive.

This applies beyond cars.

A free business opportunity.

A free piece of equipment.

A free subscription trial.

A free anything.

> **ASK YOURSELF**
>
> What will this cost me after I have it?

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04 — FIXED COSTS ARE THE REAL LEAK

For years, I could look at individual purchases and wonder where my money went.

Food.

Restaurants.

Shopping.

Subscriptions.

Little purchases.

But when I looked at the bigger picture, housing and vehicles were doing far more damage.

That's important because cutting $5 here and $10 there doesn't necessarily solve a structural problem.

Sometimes the problem is the commitment you made months or years ago.

Small expenses are visible.

Fixed costs can quietly own your future.

05 — TRACKING ISN'T THE SAME AS KNOWING

I tracked thousands and thousands of transactions.

I had records going back years.

But tracking everything didn't automatically mean I understood my financial situation.

There's a difference between:

> **“I know where my money went.”**

and:

> **“I know what financial decisions I'm making and what they're going to do to my future.”**

Tracking is useful.

But tracking your past doesn't automatically give you control over your future.

Track your past. Manage your future.

06 — MONEY OWED TO YOU IS NOT MONEY YOU HAVE

This one hurt me.

I had money I expected to receive.

An accident settlement took around 17 months.

But life didn't stop while I waited.

I still had bills.

I still needed transportation.

I still had problems.

And I made financial decisions based partly on the assumption that future money would eventually arrive.

That's dangerous.

Expected money isn't available money.

Until the money is actually in your account, treat it like what it is:

money you don't have yet.

III

THE DON'T DECIDE YET FRAMEWORK

This is the part I wish I had before I bought the first Kia.

You don't need a spreadsheet with 47 formulas.

You don't need to become a personal-finance expert.

You need to create enough space between:

FEELING THE PROBLEM

and

COMMITTING YOUR MONEY.

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01 — STOP

If you're angry, desperate, embarrassed, scared, overwhelmed, or extremely excited:

Don't sign while you're desperate because your current car died, excited because you fell in love with a car, embarrassed about what you're driving, or under dealership pressure.

Your emotions aren't proof that the decision is wrong.

But they are a reason to slow down.

> **Would I make this same decision if I felt completely calm right now?**

If you're not sure, stop.

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02 — NAME THE ACTUAL PROBLEM

Don't start with the solution.

Start with the problem.

Instead of:

> “I need this car.”

Ask:

> **“What problem am I actually trying to solve?”**

“I need reliable transportation so I can get to work” is very different from “I need this specific $35,000 car.”

Once you identify the actual problem, you can find more solutions.

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03 — LIST THREE OTHER OPTIONS

This is intentionally annoying.

Do it anyway.

Repair the current car. Buy something cheaper. Buy used. Borrow temporarily. Rent temporarily. Public transportation. Wait.

Not because any particular alternative is automatically correct.

The point isn't that the alternatives will always be better.

The point is to stop yourself from believing:

“This is my only option.”

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04 — CALCULATE THE REAL COST

Don't calculate only the number someone is trying to sell you.

Calculate **your number. (Click here to use my calculator now if you haven't)**

Include:

- Upfront cost
- Monthly payment
- Insurance
- Fuel / charging
- Maintenance
- Fees / registration / taxes
- Existing debt / negative equity
- Other recurring costs

You don't need perfect numbers.

You need a more honest number than the monthly payment.

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05 — CHECK THE FUTURE

Ask:

If my income stays exactly the same for 12 months, can I comfortably afford this?

What if my income drops?

What if the money I'm expecting never arrives?

What happens if this goes badly?

Who else could be affected?

Don't only calculate the best-case scenario.

Think about the version where life doesn't cooperate.

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06 — WAIT

If it's not a genuine emergency, give yourself time.

Not because waiting automatically makes the decision better.

Because **you might think differently once the emotion passes.**

Ask:

> **What happens if I wait 24 hours?**

Then:

> **What happens if I wait a week?**

If the answer is “nothing,” you probably don't need to decide today.

A salesperson may want your decision today.

Your financial future doesn't.

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07 — DECIDE

Now decide.

Buy it. Lease it. Choose something cheaper. Repair what you have. Wait.

Not because someone told you what to do.

Not because I told you what to do.

Because you understand the actual problem, your alternatives, the real cost, the risks, the future consequences, who else could be affected, and whether you were reacting emotionally.

And if you still want to do it?

Do it.

The goal isn't to make every decision perfectly.

The goal is:

INTENTIONAL DECISIONS

instead of:

REACTIVE DECISIONS.

IV

BEFORE I SAY YES

The 5-minute decision tool

> 💡 **LEARN IT HERE. USE IT AT THE END.**
>
> Below, I'll walk you through each part of the **Before I Say Yes** tool so you understand what to ask and why it matters.
>
> **You don't need to fill anything out yet.**
>
> At the end of this guide, you'll get the complete interactive version to **duplicate into your own Notion workspace and use whenever a big financial decision comes up.**

THE DECISION

What am I about to commit to?

→ Type your answer here.

THE ACTUAL PROBLEM

What problem am I actually trying to solve?

→ Type your answer here.

MY OTHER OPTIONS

Option 1

→ Type here.

Option 2

→ Type here.

Option 3

→ Type here.

THE REAL COST

COST	AMOUNT
Upfront	$
Monthly payment	$
Insurance	$
Fuel / charging	$
Maintenance	$
Fees / taxes	$
Existing debt / negative equity	$
Other	$
REAL MONTHLY COST	**$**
12-MONTH COST	**$**
TOTAL COMMITMENT	**$**

MY ASSUMPTIONS

What needs to go right for this decision to work?

→ Type here.

THE DOWNSIDE

If I'm wrong, what happens?

→ Type here.

THE RIPPLE EFFECT

Who else could be affected by this decision?

→ Type here.

EMOTIONAL CHECK

How am I feeling right now and what's influencing this car decision?

- [ ] My current car is unreliable
- [ ] I urgently need transportation for work
- [ ] I'm tired of dealing with my current car
- [ ] I'm embarrassed by what I drive
- [ ] I'm excited about this specific car
- [ ] I feel like I deserve an upgrade
- [ ] The salesperson/deal is creating urgency
- [ ] I'm expecting to earn more money soon
- [ ] I'm expecting money that hasn't arrived yet
- [ ] I'm trying to escape another car problem
- [ ] I'm calm and I've been considering this for a while

THE FUTURE TEST

If my income stays exactly the same for 12 months, can I comfortably afford this?

- [ ] YES
- [ ] NO
- [ ] I'M NOT SURE

If the money I'm expecting never arrives, can I still handle this?

- [ ] YES
- [ ] NO

If this goes badly, can I live with the consequences?

- [ ] YES
- [ ] NO

I'M NOT SURE

Would I still make this decision if nobody else knew about it?

- [ ] YES
- [ ] NO
- [ ] I'M NOT SURE

MY DECISION

🟡 WAIT

- [ ] I need more time or information.

🔴 DON'T DO IT

- [ ] The risk isn't worth it.

🟢 DO IT

- [ ] I've considered the alternatives, understand the cost, and I'm comfortable with the consequences.

One last question

What would Future Me want me to remember about this decision?

→ Write it here.

BEFORE YOU CLOSE THIS

I don't want you to finish this guide thinking:

> **“Damn. I should never make a financial mistake.”**

That's impossible.

You're going to make mistakes.

I'm going to make more.

The goal isn't perfection.

The goal is to make cheaper mistakes.

I wish someone had sat me down before that first Kia and said:

> **“You're not just buying a car. You're making a decision that can affect the next several years of your life.”**

Maybe I would have listened.

Maybe I wouldn't have.

But at least I would have had someone force me to stop and think.

That's what this guide is for.

I CAN'T GO BACK.

I can't get the money back.

I can't undo the cars.

I can't undo the payments.

I can't undo the opportunities I feel like I wasted.

I can't go back to LA five years ago and make different decisions.

And maybe that's the hardest part.

For a long time, I looked at everything I lost and thought:

> **“I wasted it.”**

The money.

The time.

The opportunity.

The version of my life I thought I was going to build.

But there's something I can still do.

I can take what happened and make it useful.

I can document the mistakes.

I can explain the patterns.

I can give someone else the questions I wish I had.

So..

I hope you stop.

Not because I'm telling you what to do.

But because your future deserves more than a decision made while you're angry, desperate, embarrassed, scared, or trying to escape a problem.

You don't have to make the perfect decision.

You just have to give yourself a chance to make a better one.

Because I learned this the hard way:

A $500 decision doesn't always cost $500.

Sometimes the first decision creates the second.

The second creates the third.

And before you know it, you're looking backward wondering how you got there.

That's what happened to me.

I spent roughly **$69,000** trying to navigate my way through car problems.

And I don't have a car to show for it.

I can't change that.

But I can make sure the experience doesn't end there.

If this helps even one person make a cheaper mistake than I did, it was worth writing.

BEFORE YOU SAY YES

STOP.

NAME THE PROBLEM.

LIST YOUR OPTIONS.

CALCULATE THE REAL COST.

CHECK THE FUTURE.

WAIT.

THEN DECIDE.

Make cheaper mistakes than I did.

Ready to use this on a real decision? Here's what to do next:

Fill out the interactive form to run your numbers and see the full decision you are about to make in a short and simple way.

- [ ] → **BEFORE I SAY YES TOOL on Tally (interactive form)**

https://tally.so/r/68gDNN

> In case you want to save the Form format: open the **Before I Say Yes Decision Tool here.** Once it opens, click **Duplicate** in the top-right corner to add your own editable copy to your Notion Workspace.

Access the Real Car Cost Calculator to run numbers on the go

- [ ] Use the embedded link or click here to open the full page.

https://real-car-cost.brunodiaz98.chatgpt.site/

💡 **30-Day Money-Back Guarantee**
Read the guide. Use the framework. Try the decision tool on a real decision.
If you genuinely don't think it was worth the money, message me within 30 days and I'll refund you.
No hoops. No convincing me. No hard feelings.